Homeowner Digging a Terrace Finds Record Viking Silver Hoard in Denmark

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A homeowner in northern Denmark set out to clear grass and stones for a new terrace and uncovered the largest silver **hoard** ever found on Danish soil. The treasure weighs more than 40 pounds (about 18.5 kilograms).

"It should have just been a few hours of hard gardening work," the anonymous finder said. After about half an hour, a tool hit something odd. Digging by hand, the person pulled out jewelry, coins, and silver bars and quickly realized the find was historic.

The homeowner contacted North Jutland Museums. **Archaeologists** led by Torben Sarauw carefully excavated the yard and recovered about 700 silver objects. The fortune had been stored in a clay pot. The top broke long ago, spilling roughly 380 pieces into the soil, while about 320 items remained in the pot's base.

The **hoard** includes silver **ingots** sorted by weight, arm rings, bracelets, and neck rings. Many pieces were cut into "**hack-silver**" bits Vikings used like small change. Among 47 coins and fragments are two **Anglo-Saxon** pennies from the reign of King Edward the Elder (899-924) and Arabic silver **dirhams**, clues to trade with England and lands farther east. **Archaeologists** also found a tiny Thor's hammer charm.

The **Anglo-Saxon** pennies suggest burial in the 10th century, when King Harald Bluetooth was uniting Denmark and spreading Christianitya time when some wealthy people may have hidden valuables. The discovery was announced in late August 2026. Under Danish law the treasure belongs to the state and will go to the National Museum of Denmark, and the finder will receive a cash reward.

Word Treasure

hoard -- A hidden collection of valuable objects, often buried long ago.

archaeologists -- Scientists who carefully dig and study objects from past human life.

hack-silver -- Silver cut into small pieces that Vikings used like money to pay for goods.

ingots -- Bars of metal, here silver sorted by weight.

dirhams -- Arabic silver coins that show long-distance trade.

Anglo-Saxon -- Related to early English kingdoms; here, pennies from King Edward the Elder's time.

Background you need

A hoard is a buried stash of valuables, often hidden during unsettled times.

Vikings sometimes cut silver into small pieces called hack-silver to use like money.

Coins from distant places can show trade links across seas and continents.

In many countries, major archaeological finds become public museum property, and finders may receive a reward.

Break it down

LEAD: Danish terrace dig reveals record Viking silver hoard
KEY EVENT: Homeowner finds jewelry, coins, and bars; museums excavate
  +- SCALE: More than 40 pounds; about 700 objects
  +- STORAGE: Clay pot that partly broke long ago
EVIDENCE: Ingots, rings, hack-silver, English and Arabic coins, Thor hammer charm
DATING: Anglo-Saxon pennies point to 10th-century burial
OUTCOME: State ownership; finder receives a reward

Why it matters

Everyday digging can uncover history that museums preserve for everyone. Coins and silver pieces teach how Vikings traded and saved wealth.

Test what you remember

1. Where was the silver hoard found?

(A) Under a school desk
(B) On a mountain glacier only
(C) A backyard in northern Denmark
(D) A museum gift shop

2. About how heavy is the hoard?

(A) Exactly one coin
(B) Two ounces
(C) One ton of gold
(D) More than 40 pounds (about 18.5 kilograms)

3. About how many silver objects did archaeologists recover?

(A) Seven
(B) Seventy thousand
(C) Two
(D) About 700

4. What is hack-silver?

(A) A modern credit card
(B) A wooden boat
(C) Cut silver pieces Vikings used like small change
(D) A type of helmet

5. Which coins suggest trade links?

(A) Bus tickets
(B) Video game coins
(C) Anglo-Saxon pennies and Arabic dirhams
(D) Only plastic tokens

6. Who keeps the treasure under Danish law?

(A) The National Museum of Denmark (the state)
(B) A sports team
(C) A private auction with no rules
(D) Only the next-door neighbor

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: D 3: D 4: C 5: C 6: A

Questions to think about

1. **Anonymous finder: Called the terrace dig the biggest surprise of a lifetime after pulling jewelry and silver from the soil.**

2. **Archaeologists (Torben Sarauw's team): Systematically excavated and interpreted the hoard's trade clues and likely 10th-century date.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):